



Plant focus: leafy greens

Easy to grow and delicious when fresh, lettuces and other salad leaves are the perfect crop for small gardens and patios.

DESPITE THEIR HIGH PRICE IN THE GROCERY STORES, lettuces and other leafy greens are easy to grow from seed, economical, and taste twice as nice when picked fresh. They are pretty plants and can be used in combination with edible flowers, such as nasturtiums and violas in container displays. To grow leafy greens, sow seeds in trays under cover in early spring and, once a good root system has developed and the plants have been acclimated to the outdoors, plant them in moist but free-draining soil in sun or part shade. Sow additional seeds directly outside starting in late spring to extend the harvest period. Keep the plants well watered and protected from slugs. Where space allows, grow head-forming lettuce and harvest when mature. For smaller plots, grow arugula, mustard greens, and loose-leaf lettuce varieties as a “cut-and-come again crop,” cutting the leaves about $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2cm) from the soil when plants are 4in (10cm) in height. When well watered, the plants will regrow to give you repeated summer crops.

USING LEAFY GREENS

Grow greens in raised beds, which are close at hand and make picking easy, with edible flowers and herbs. Incorporate varieties with colored or frilly leaves into bedding schemes as foliage plants, or use to edge beds. Crops can also be grown in individual pots on a windowsill.



Loose-leaved greens can be harvested as “microgreens,” grown in pots and trays. Where space is limited, plant them in a green-wall growing system.

Swiss chard grows best in light shade where it is less prone to bolting. Cut individual leaves when young and tender, leaving the base to regrow.



TYPES OF LEAFY GREEN



Romaine lettuces Also known as cos lettuces, they produce a tall head of crisp leaves with a rib down the center of each leaf. Leave plants to form a head before harvesting.



Butterhead lettuces Also known as Boston or Bibb lettuce, these produce tender leaves with the sweetest at the center forming a loose heart. Provide them with enough space to mature fully.



Loose-leaf lettuces This group produces loose green or red leaves without a central heart and includes oak- and frilly-leaved forms, such as ‘Lollo Rossa’ (above).